

Rabbits and rodents

Rodents—which include rats, mice, and squirrels—were as plentiful in prehistoric times as they are today. Rabbits, too, hopped and jumped across the landscape in much the same way as their modern descendants. Although most were small herbivores, some species grew to a scarily large size.

Castoroides

CASS-tore-OY-deez

- **When** 3 million–10,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Lakes, ponds, swamps
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Also known as the giant beaver, *Castoroides* was about the size of a black bear and was one of the largest rodents ever to have lived. Modern beavers have chisel-like front teeth, but *Castoroides*'s teeth were broad and large. It had shorter hindlimbs, but its tail was longer and narrower. Like modern beavers, it lived in or near water and perhaps built small dams and dome-shaped lodges (beaver homes).

20,000-year-old fossil tooth of a giant beaver.



Palaeocastor

PAY-lee-oh-CASS-tor

- **When** 25 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA, Japan
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 15 in (38 cm)
- **Diet** Plants

Palaeocastor was a much smaller and earlier beaver than *Castoroides*. This land-dwelling animal dug deep burrows with its front teeth

rather than building dams and lodges. Fossilized burrows with *Palaeocastor* skeletons and tooth marks on the walls were found in 1891. These famous burrows were called “devil’s corkscrews” because of their narrow, spiral shape.

